

3. Emperor Xiaowen's Compromise Was Not a Success

Emperor Xiaowen was highly likely not the first to realize the possibility of such a compromise, nor was he, of course, the last ethnic minority monarch to make such a choice. Yet undeniably, the "**Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise**" (地主—官僚妥协) movement during his reign exerted the most colossal impact on the history of the entire East, due to its unique position in the long river of history. Simultaneously, driven by the "historical momentum" (时势) of the Xianbei nation at the end of the 5th century CE, Emperor Xiaowen's reforms produced highly dramatic consequences.

The most direct and obvious long-term consequence of bureaucratizing rather than feudalizing one's own nation is that the cultural characteristics of the ethnic minority inevitably and completely dissolve into the conquered nation. The reason is exactly as previously stated: since the conquerors abandoned control over the property rights of land (the core being ownership) within the empire's territory, and chose instead to transform into non-productive professional bureaucrats (脱产的职业官僚) who did not directly possess the means of production (生产资料), this lifestyle—divorced from social production—made it exceedingly difficult for the conquerors to create a new culture adapted to the new productive forces.

On the other hand, because the conquerors occupied the politically dominant ruling position in the new society, it was impossible for them not to be deeply involved in state governance. This is fundamentally different from the Jewish people or Jains in the past, who were able to carefully preserve their characteristics on the margins of society. However, relative to the conquered Han people, the culture of the conquerors was too backward. Consequently, under the system post-compromise, if the conquerors wished to govern and pacify the state, they had no choice but to utilize Han culture, because they themselves were no longer capable of creating a culture fitting the circumstances.

The result of this dynamic was that the conquerors, unlike their counterparts in Europe, the Middle East, and the Indochinese Peninsula, not only failed to elevate their relatively backward culture and root it into the newly conquered lands, but also degenerated within a short time to the point where they were indistinguishable from the Han people. Therefore, if we imagine the perspective of "Xianbei Nationalism" (鲜卑民族主义), Tuoba Hong (Emperor Xiaowen) is not merely a sinner and a traitor to the Xianbei in the short term; in the long term, his crime is monumentally greater, for he thoroughly annihilated the Xianbei nation.

But what is even more dramatic is that, although Emperor Xiaowen attempted to resolutely execute the policy of bureaucratization, in reality, for the Xianbei people, this was not something that could be accomplished so quickly. The reason is simple: there were already far too many Xianbei people in Northern China.

In fact, one can easily notice that barbarian incursions into an empire's territory are divided into two stages. During the zenith of a classical empire, its territory and sphere of influence extended far beyond the settlements of the civilized nations, thereby incorporating frontier chieftains into the empire's (often indirect) jurisdiction. Thus, as the empire increasingly disintegrated during the process of **feudalization**, the so-called barbarians who were the first to participate in this process were actually "naturalized" (归化) ethnic minorities who had long lived within the empire's borders. The chieftains of these minorities accepted the empire's investiture, held imperial official titles, and

their soldiers fought for the empire like mercenaries; these things had been happening for one or two centuries.

On another note, while the civil society of the late classical empire trended toward collapse—forcing the empire to rely on the support of barbarian soldiers and thus gradually acquiescing to barbarian migration into the empire's interior—the empire inevitably did not lose control overnight. Therefore, it could still restrict the scale of this inward migration and adopt advantageous methods to resettle the migrating tribes. This meant that a substantial portion of the members among the naturalized barbarians already had a lifestyle indistinguishable from that of the empire's citizens, while those members who still remained in a clan-tribal state and possessed a powerful need for **feudalization** were relatively too few.

Thus, following the disintegration of the empire, within the first wave of ethnic minority invasions, these already semi-imperialized barbarians were neither psychologically inclined to completely discard the old imperial system—to the extent of viewing it as **Chonggang Junfu / Towering Mountains** (重冈俊阜)—in favor of a more thorough **feudal system**, nor were they capable of doing so in terms of the balance of power. Their tribal armies were indeed too small to suppress the resistance of the demographically dominant native inhabitants of the original empire.

Consequently, the first batch of minority regimes established upon the corpse of the empire often adopted the attitude of a "paperhanger" (裱糊匠), positioning themselves as the orthodox successors to the empire and striving their utmost to maintain the classical system that was already unsustainable. In China, the Han regime (汉政权) established by the Xiongnu chieftain Liu Yuan (刘渊) in the 4th century CE, and Fu Jian (苻坚)—the Di (氐族) chieftain and ruler of the Former Qin Dynasty (前秦) who unified Northern China—are highly typical examples.

Those truly capable of realizing the enterprise of **feudalization** (封建化) were the second wave of barbarians who followed closely behind. They rapidly approached the empire's borders, possessing a relatively more backward culture and less contact with the empire, yet their numbers were vastly larger. This batch of barbarians did not harbor the identification with the imperial system seen in the first wave of naturalized barbarians. However, during their movement toward civilized regions, they elevated their productive forces to a level approaching the early stages of **feudalization**, which endowed them with an intense thirst for land. They would utilize their superior military force to drive deep into the territory, forcefully confiscating land from the remnants of the empire and the previously entered barbarians, allowing their own tribesmen to firmly control this newly emerged, most crucial means of production (生产资料).

In China, the Xianbei (鲜卑) seemed inherently tasked with such a historical mission. The situation after the fall of the Roman Empire was similar. Perry Anderson, in his work *Passages from Antiquity to Feudalism* (《从古代到封建主义的过渡》), also argued that **feudalization** in the Western Empire occurred twice according to the aforementioned typology.

It is precisely because the Xianbei were too numerous, their demand for **feudalization** (i.e., for land) was too vigorous, and they completely lacked a sense of identification with the Chinese bureaucratic system, that Emperor Xiaowen's "bureaucratization" (官僚化) measures were destined to cater only to an extremely small minority of the Xianbei upper echelon. From the very beginning, these measures severely betrayed the overall interests of the Xianbei nation, inciting extreme anger

among the vast majority of lower-class Xianbei—who remained in a state of neither being feudalized nor bureaucratized, and were not even agriculturally settled.

Consequently, less than 30 years after the relocation of the capital to Luoyang (洛阳), massive rebellions erupted in the *Six Frontier Garrisons* (六镇) of Northern Wei, stationed by these Xianbei who felt profoundly betrayed. This interval is astonishingly short. Even calculating at 16 years per generation, 30 years is less than two generations. By comparison, even after enduring the severe destruction inflicted upon Soviet society during the Stalin era, the Soviet Union survived for 38 years after Stalin's death. This somewhat illustrates that Emperor Xiaowen's reforms could not possibly have been as successful as official historiography claims.

中文原文：

3. 孝文帝的妥协并非成功

孝文帝大概率不是第一个意识到可以进行这种妥协的人，也当然不是最后一个做出这样选择的少数民族君主。但是毫无疑问，他执政时期的“地主—官僚妥协”运动因为其在历史长河中位置的特殊性，对整个东方的历史产生了最为巨大的影响。同时也是因为鲜卑民族在公元五世纪末的“时势”所至，孝文帝的改革产生了戏剧性的影响。

将本民族官僚化而非封建化的一个最直接并且明显的长期结果便是，少数民族的文化特征必然彻底消解到被征服民族之中。其原因正如之前所述，既然征服者放弃了掌控帝国疆域中的土地产权（核心是所有权），而选择转变成成为脱产的职业官僚，不直接地拥有生产资料，那么这种远离社会生产的生活就使得征服者们难以创造出适应于新生产力的新文化。另一个方面在于，征服者在新社会中处于政治上的统治地位，所以他们不可能不深度参与到国家治理当中，这和犹太人、耆那教徒当年得以在社会边缘小心翼翼地维护自己的特征是完全不同的。然而征服者的文化相对于被征服的汉人而言又太过落后，于是在妥协之后的体制下，征服者要想能够平治国家，就不得不使用汉人的文化，因为他们自己已经无法再创造符合形势的文化了。这种作用的结果是，征服者非但不能像欧洲，中东和中南半岛的同行一样把自己相对落后的文化进行提升并根植在新征服的土地上，而且在不长的时间内就蜕变到和汉人没什么区别了。所以如果我们想象一个“鲜卑民族主义”的观点，那么孝文帝元宏不但在短期内是鲜卑的罪人和叛徒，而从长期来看他的罪行只能更大，因为他将彻底消灭鲜卑民族。

但是更为戏剧性的一点是，尽管孝文帝试图坚决地执行官僚化政策，但是实际上对于鲜卑人来说这并不是一个能够那么快就完成的事情，原因很简单，那就是鲜卑人在中国北方已经太多了。事实上，人们很容易注意到蛮族对帝国疆域的侵略分为两个阶段。在古典帝国鼎盛时期，其疆域和势力范围远远越过了那些文明民族的聚集地，从而将边疆酋长纳入帝国的（当然很可能是间接的）管辖。于是当帝国在封建化进程中日益瓦解的时候，首先得以参与进这个过程的所谓蛮族，实际上已经是在帝国疆域内生活已久的“归化”少数民族。这些少数民族的首领接受帝国的册封，领有帝国的官衔，他们的士兵像佣兵一样为帝国作战，这些事情已经发生了一两个世纪。而另一方面来说，古典帝国晚期的公民社会虽然趋于瓦解，导致帝国不得不依赖于蛮族士兵的支持，所以会逐渐默许蛮族向帝国内地的迁徙。但是帝国必然没有骤然之间就丧失控制力，因此仍然能够限制这种内迁的规模，并且采取有利的方式安置内迁的部众。这就使得归化蛮族里面相当大一部分成员其生活方式已经与帝国的公民无异，而仍然处于氏族部落状态，拥有强大封建化需求的成员相对而言太少了。

于是在帝国瓦解之后，第一波少数民族侵入的浪潮中，这些已经半帝国化的蛮族既不会在心理上倾向于完全舍弃帝国的旧制度，以至视其为“重冈俊阜”，而采取更加彻底的封建体制，而且在力量对比上也难以做到这一点，他们的部民军队的确太少，难以弹压人口占优势的原帝国本土居民的反抗。因而在帝国尸体上建立的第一批少数民族政权，往往采取一种裱糊匠的态度，以帝国的正统继承者自居，并

且尽力去维持已经维持不下去的古典体制。在中国，公元四世纪匈奴首领刘渊建立的汉政权以及统一中国北方的氏族首领，前秦王朝的统治者苻坚就是非常典型的例子。真正能够实现封建化事业的是尾随而来的第二批蛮族，他们迅速地接近帝国边境，文化相对更落后，与帝国的接触更少，但是人数却更为庞大。这一批蛮族不存在第一批归化蛮族那样对帝国体制的认同，但是在向文明地区运动的过程中提升了自己的生产力以至于接近了封建化早期的水平，这使得他们拥有对土地的强烈的渴求。他们会利用具有优势的军事力量长驱直入，以武力从帝国的遗民和先进入的蛮族手中没收土地，让自己的部民牢牢控制这一新晋最重要的生产资料。在中国，鲜卑人似乎原本就肩负着这样的历史使命。而罗马帝国覆灭之后的情况类似，佩里安德森在他的著作《从古代到封建主义的过渡》中，也认为封建化在西帝国依以上类型发生了两次。

正是由于鲜卑人的人数太多，对于封建化（也就是对土地）的需求太过旺盛，而又缺乏对于中国官僚体制的认同感。孝文皇帝的“官僚化”举措注定只能照顾到极少数的鲜卑高层，在一开始就严重背弃了鲜卑民族的整体利益，使得大部分仍然处于既未封建化，也未官僚化，甚至还非农业定居状态的底层鲜卑人感到极为恼怒。于是在迁都洛阳不到 30 年的时候，在北魏北方六个由这些感到被背叛的鲜卑人所驻守边镇就爆发了声势浩大的起义，这种间隔短到令人吃惊。即使按 16 年一代人来算，30 年也不超过两代人，而即使是经历了斯大林时期苏联社会遭受的严重破坏，苏联在斯大林死后也存在于 38 年。这多少可以看出孝文帝改革根本不可能像官方史学说得那么成功。